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The Generous Demands of Duty

The concept of duty was first introduced to me while I stood— eyes downcast— between an innocent little puppy, cluelessly wagging its tail near a foul-smelling puddle, and a grown woman named “mom” who was frowning down at me. “It’s your responsibility to clean up this mess since you didn’t let him outside.” Why, I wondered, must I do this ghastly, dreadful task? It smells icky and I don’t want to. As a child, the only consequence I would have to wrestle with if I defied my mom’s command to clean up beloved Fluffy’s “duty” was a brief stint behind bars and without joy; aka, a few minutes in the time-out corner. But for a physician, the consequences of neglecting duty carry a heavy enormity. It could spell an ache that refuses to quit, no matter how many pills grandma pops, or it could mean a debilitating disease that one has to suffer everyday. It could even mean the death of someone’s child. But physicians likely share my distaste for carrying out inconvenient, and sometimes risky obligations. How then, should medical professionals define their duty to the world, when so much is at stake?

Two philosophers, Tomlinson and Camus, offer answers to this question in their respective works “Caring for risky patients: duty or virtue?” and *The Plague*. Camus’s narrator, Dr. Rieux, proposes an alternative solution. In this paper, I will argue that not just physicians but all humans have a dual duty to both their individual happiness and the collective care of others, and these duties must be carefully balanced.

Firstly, Tomlinson’s solution asserts that the language of duty fails to encompass the responsibility of physicians to treat risky patients, but these doctors should be recognized and commended for virtuous behavior that is in line with the highest ideals

of their profession. Tomlinson starts by explaining how arguments utilizing duty fall short- or at a minimum, prove that only some physicians should take on some risks. This can be better understood by noting that Tomlinson characterized duty as “set[ting] a minimal standard of conduct, and as such its performance deserves no special praise” (Tomlinson). Duty, to Tomlinson, is the bare minimum. However, he also notes the absurdity of a situation where “paediatricians...quietly sit on their hands when volunteers are needed to provide care for a young girl infected with monkeypox” (Tomlinson). Tomlinson posits that the intangible quality in this situation, striking a reader as wrong or somehow off, is not a result of a failure to meet minimum standards of duty. Instead, it represents a failure to exhibit virtue and a result of doctors who are “defective in their professional character.”

Rieux would disagree with Tomlinson, and instead demands a radical new understanding of duty; in which taking risks in the pursuit of caring for others is a duty unassociated with any job, but rather constitutes the baseline duty humankind has to one another. However, this is not the only definition of duty Camus posits through his characters. Note Rieux’s statement that “because the plague became the duty of a few, it appeared as what it actually was- everyone’s business. That is good. But you don’t congratulate a teacher for instructing that two and two equals four...” (Camus, 140-141). Rieux diverts from Tomlinson by setting a much higher bar for duty- as he states that the “duty” of fighting the plague and the risks associated with it are simply “everyone’s business,” and undeserving of a higher form of recognition. Indeed, under Tomlinson’s purview of the world, Rieux should be seen as supremely heroic for taking supererogatory actions from the start of the plague to care for the city, but Rieux

remarks that “there’s no question of heroism in all this” (175). Rieux rejects any notion that these actions constitute heroism- or as Tomlinson would say, virtuousness and idealism. Instead, Rieux supposes that what is commonly understood as virtue and heroism is actually just common decency and an innate human duty.

However, Rieux doesn’t associate this duty with being a doctor. Though he fulfills this responsibility in his professional role, he believes everyone possesses this duty and should fulfill it in a way that makes sense in their own lives. He states that it was “normal for old Castel to put all his trust and energy into making serums locally...” and “it was normal that Grand... ran a sort of administrative office for all the public health squads” despite managing other responsibilities and burning himself out (142). He expects all humans to participate in this duty, which further differentiates him from Tomlinson.

Though I was initially more inclined to agree with Rieux’s purview, his extreme commitment to fulfilling his self-identified duty toward the collective betterment of humans leads him to abandon his individual responsibility towards his family. He exhibits reckless abandon for his elderly mother by continuing to live with her, despite seeing sick patients and constantly exposing himself (and by extension, her) to the contagion. Moreover, as his wife leaves the city, he asks his wife “for her forgiveness,” stating “he should have watched over her, and he had neglected her often” (11).

Another character, Tarrou, is equally as dedicated to the fight against the plague, but he balances familial and friendship duties much better. He proposes that he and Rieux take a break for “an hour of friendship,” and says “It’s stupid to live under the plague alone. Of course, a man must fight for the victims. But if he stops loving anything else, then what use is his fight?” (274). While Rieux establishes an important collective duty each

human has to his fellow human, he neglects a personal duty we have to ourselves to cultivate meaning through things like family and friendship. I think we would be wise to heed Tarrou's advice and balance these two duties, as hard as it may be.

Works Cited

Camus, Albert. *The Plague*. Translated by Laura Marris, Vintage Books, a Division of Penguin Random House LLC, 2022.

Tomlinson T. Caring for risky patients: duty or virtue? *Journal of Medical Ethics* 2008;34:458-462.